Key Messages

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- Despite the resumption of most economic activities to near normal levels, the socio-political climate remains unpredictable and fragile. The operating environment of the Parliament and insecurity, among other factors, creates uncertainty, which still risks disrupting the calm observed for more than three months. In the event of renewed civil unrest, similar to that seen in 2019, household access to food and income would be more significant impacted. However, based on recent calm, broad stability is expected through at least September.
- Rainfall deficits during the 2019 second rainy season contribute to lower than average yields of the currently harvested winter bean season in the Nord-Est, Nord, Nippes, Nord-Ouest, and in some municipalities in Ouest departments. However, the harvest is closer to average in the Greater South of the country (with the exception of Nippes) and Artibonite, where beans, maize, peanuts, rice and market garden produce are currently being harvested, in addition to the harvest of bananas and roots. The availability of these foods is driving some improvements in food security.
- Despite these improvements, high prices of basic food products, persistently low employment opportunities, and the negative effects of the socio-political crisis more broadly are all negatively impacting many poor households' ability to sufficiently access their food and non-food needs. In areas of greatest concern, including those in which production is likely to be below average and income-earning opportunities are low, Stressed (IPC Phase 2) and Crisis (IPC Phase 3) outcomes are anticipated through September 2020.

NATIONAL OVERVIEW

Current Situation

Socio-political context: Since the second half of November, economic activity has returned to normal, with the exception of the hotel industry. Transport, trade, schooling and public administration have resumed. However, developments remain unpredictable.

In addition, the operating environment of the Parliament and insecurity, among other issues, are creating uncertainty, which could jeopardize the apparent calm observed for over three months.

The situation is particularly worrying in and around the metropolitan area of Port-au-Prince, where there has been a wave of kidnappings since the beginning of the year. In addition, a protest movement started around two weeks ago by Haitian national police officers is manifesting in confrontations, sometimes violent, between the national police and the Haitian armed forces.

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Climate conditions and outlook: Cumulative rainfall over the month of January was around average overall, but with irregular temporal and geographical distribution. At the beginning of February, however, rainfall was below normal levels. In some regions, such as Nippes, Centre, Nord-Ouest and Ouest, the early end to the rains in late January is delaying land preparation activities, which normally start in January and February in preparation for spring planting in March and April.

Impact on seasonal crop production: Except for irrigated plains and semi-humid mountain areas, the temporal and geographical irregularity of rainfall has disrupted current crops, negatively affected the performance of the winter harvest, and delayed land preparation activities for the spring season.

Urban and regional markets: With the exception of Croix-des-Bossales market, which is operating on a limited basis, markets are continuing to function normally and are well supplied, mostly with imported produce, and well-stocked. Large distribution centers for imported food products are also well-stocked.

There is low availability of local foods, apart from yams and bananas, due to poor fall and winter harvests in some parts of the country.

Price trends: Food prices remained relatively stable in January and February. The price of imported rice fell between November and January, despite a volatile world price trend (OSIRIZ report no. 191, January 2020). There was an average fall of almost 5 percent at the national level, with a 6 lb pot (*marmite*) of rice selling for around 270 gourdes, compared with 283 gourdes in December. Further reductions are expected in February.

According to FEWS NET sources, this situation is due to the improved movement of goods across the country. Food products, including rice, can now reach all departments.